

A leap into history

Three years after he suffered a freak injury in training that nearly ended his plans as a collegiate athlete, **Lokesh Sathyanathan** has become the first Indian long jumper to win an NCAA title.

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Few people had their eye on Lokesh Sathyanathan when he first arrived in Fayetteville, Arkansas, to take part in the men's long jump competition at the NCAA Indoor Championships in March. The 26-year-old wasn't expecting them to. The NCAA Indoor Championships are the highest level of competition in the indoor track and field calendar — considered the most prestigious form of collegiate sport in the world.

The standard of competition is nothing less than that of a world-level meet. Lokesh, competing for Tarleton State University — a relatively small college that had never won an individual track and field title at this competition — was, to put it mildly, not a favourite.

"One day before the competition, the only people who recognised me were the ones who already knew me — probably just my coach and teammates," he recalls.

That's not the case any longer. On March 13, Lokesh leapt a career-best 8.21m to win gold. The jump set a new Indian indoor national record and moved him to third on the all-time list of Indian long jumpers across all competitions. It also made him only the fourth Indian to win gold at the NCAA Championships — joining triple jumper M.S. Gill, discus thrower Vikas Gowda, and decathlete and high jumper Tejaswin Shankar.

